TOPIC 2 · PERSONALISATION, .RULES AND SKILLS FOR EXCEL
LAB 3 THEME · PERSONALISATION

# Lab 3 — Personalise Copilot in Excel for Consistent Service Reports

| | |
|---|---|
| **Maps to** | LO2: distinguish account Personalisation, workbook .Rules and reusable Skills; configure, apply and verify each using water-service evidence. |
| **Duration** | 20 minutes |
| **Tools** | Microsoft 365 Copilot in Excel · OneDrive |
| **Mock data** | data/Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx |
| **Course** | GenAI for Engineers · v2.3 |
| **Prompts** | https://tertiarycourses.github.io/IES-GenAI-for-Engineers/prompts/#lab-3 |

## Goal

Configure temporary account-level display and explanation preferences, test them in two copies of the same verified Northstar workbook, and distinguish preferences from workbook-specific definitions. A task-specific prompt can supersede Personalisation. Restore your previous settings after the exercise.

## What You Will Do

Configure temporary account-level display and explanation preferences, test them in two copies of the same verified Northstar workbook, and distinguish preferences from workbook-specific definitions. A task-specific prompt can supersede Personalisation. Restore your previous settings after the exercise.

## What You Will Build

Northstar_Personalisation_Test.xlsx, a two-workbook preference comparison and a private note confirming settings restored.

## Prerequisites

- Microsoft 365 account with Copilot available in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and Outlook. Availability depends on the assigned licence and tenant settings; confirm access with the trainer before class.
- Desktop Excel on Windows or Mac is recommended; save working copies to your assigned OneDrive course folder with AutoSave on. Do not overwrite the supplied input.
- Download this whole lab folder. All files are synthetic; work-genai is your own learner output folder.

**Data note**

Northstar Water Services is a fictional water-pipe maintenance and service company. All service hubs, staff and work orders are synthetic. Use the fixed reporting date 2026-09-30; missing facts remain UNKNOWN. Proposals do not change real assignments. Training email drafts are never sent.

## Steps

**Step 1.** Open this lab's clean data/Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx and save working copies as Northstar_Personalisation_Test.xlsx and Northstar_Preferences_Copy.xlsx in work-genai. Confirm 120 unique IDs, reporting date 2026-09-30 and cost S$35,827.50. Neither copy needs a .Rules sheet or an installed Skill for this test.

**PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt**

```
EXCEL - CHAT ONLY:
Inspect tblWorkOrders and Control for Northstar Water Services. State the clean row count,
reporting date and recorded cost. Explain why display preferences should not change source
values or reporting definitions. Do not edit.
```

**Step 2.** In Copilot select Settings (...) > Personalization. Keep your existing settings in a private local note, then temporarily enter these four preferences: Use S$ with two decimal places and thousands separators for currency displays. Display dates as DD-MMM-YYYY. Prefer structured references when writing Excel formulas. Start explanations with a short plain-English summary before the detail. Select Save. Preferences apply to your account on subsequent prompts; they are not stored in or shared with the workbook.

**Step 3.** In the first working copy request a small output using your saved preferences. Review the plan before allowing editing. Confirm the date displays 30-Sep-2026 in both copies. Inspect the formulas and number formats in the new Preference_Check sheet; do not accept rounded or rewritten source values.

**PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt**

```
EXCEL - PLAN:
Plan a Preference_Check sheet showing Control!B2 reporting date, total work orders and
recorded Cost_SGD from tblWorkOrders for Northstar Water Services. Use my saved display and
explanation preferences. Preserve Work_Orders, IDs, owners and exact values.

EXCEL - ALLOW EDITING:
Apply the reviewed Preference_Check plan with structured-reference formulas. Show a short
explanation first and leave the source unchanged.
```

**Step 4.** Open the second copy using the same signed-in account and a new Copilot chat. Do not repeat the preference text in this request. Compare both output displays and formula references; record actual behaviour in the Evidence_Log sheet. A missed preference is a finding to clarify, not proof of a guaranteed rule.

**PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt**

```
EXCEL - ALLOW EDITING:
In this second Northstar workbook, create Preference_Check with formula-backed Control!B2
reporting date, total work orders and recorded Cost_SGD. Follow my saved preferences, preserve
source records and explain the result briefly.
```

**Step 5.** Return to the first workbook. Test a specific task instruction that changes only the result display to four decimal places. Verify S$35,827.5000 displays while the numeric value remains 35827.5. Record the comparison; do not alter the saved account settings or source.

**PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt**

```
EXCEL - ALLOW EDITING:
For this task only, display the recorded cost result in Preference_Check with four decimal
places. Keep its formula and exact numeric value unchanged. Do not modify source cells or my
saved preferences.
```

**Step 6.** Explain the scope distinction, log the prompts and your observed checks, then return to Settings (...) > Personalization, restore your previous preferences and Save. Keep the restoration note private; do not upload personal account settings to the shared course folder.

**PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt**

```
EXCEL - CHAT ONLY:
Explain which choices in this exercise belong to my account, which belong to this Northstar
workbook and which apply only to one prompt. Use the results I actually observed. Do not claim
my preferences are shared with another person or added to the workbook.
```

## Sample Prompts

Use the app labelled for each prompt (or adapt it). Name the table and columns, state the output, and always verify the result. Use the linked prompts web page for one-click Copy buttons.

**Copy-ready prompts:** https://tertiarycourses.github.io/IES-GenAI-for-Engineers/prompts/#lab-3

| # | Purpose | Prompt |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Scope | State actual source, report date and selected scope before acting. |
| 2 | Verify | Explain the source/formula checks and preserve unknowns and original records. |

## Test It

| Check | Expected result |
|---|---|
| Source controls | Both copies retain120 unique IDs, original owners/statuses and exact cost 35827.50. |
| Display check | Saved S$ two-decimal/date/explanation preferences are checked in two workbooks; observed misses are recorded. |
| Specific request | The output can show35,827.5000 without changing its value or the saved preferences. |
| Restoration | Previous account preferences restored; private baseline note stays outside public courseware. |

## Troubleshooting

| If this happens | Fix |
|---|---|
| Copilot cannot find the source | Use the app file picker to select the actual OneDrive file. A typed local path or a different app chat is not shared context. If needed copy only the verified snapshot into the current app. |
| A total disagrees with Control | Clear dashboard filters to All, check table extent and duplicate IDs, recalculate, then compare definitions and reporting date. Reconcile before continuing. |
| The named feature is missing | Confirm the correct assigned account, English display language and app version. Use the stated manual practice route; record feature unavailable. This is not evidence that a native skill ran. |

## Challenge

Repeat the task for one different site and explain how the filter scope changes the result. Keep the original verified output.

## Reflection

Which evidence proves the output is correct, and which decision still needs a person?